

# Circle of Life

Of dark nights, eerie sounds, high nerves, pizzas and ice creams

It was a dark, stormy night. Lightning rattled the window panes while the slashing rain washed the pale-faced building that stood as the solitary spectator of a sulking moor. Within the edifice lurked creatures with deep circles under their eyes and an eerie chant of "Issue closing, final proofs, comparison table validation..." hung like thick smoke in the air.

Issue Closing—two words that we have learned to associate with pandemonium and loss of hair. We come to work and buzz like busy bees at our monitors and keyboards all day. But the late night sessions, which are an omen of the approaching closing date, bring out the dark side that hides within us all. Nerves are high-strung; energy levels are low and the well-hidden quirks of every Digster surfaces from behind their mask of calm demeanour.

Take the case of Veer, a writer here at Digit. An otherwise unassuming individual, he is transformed into a sleep shunning, headphone-happy bundle of nerves come issue closing. But that is not the problem that had us up-in-arms that night in July. Breaking the monotone and grabbing the attention of the otherwise keyboard-happy 'Technology Journalists' (as we like to call ourselves), was a singular and eerie whistling. We had been working endlessly through the night and were decidedly feeling edgy. So it was not without reason that Sveta, our features editor

was startled. The eerie whistling was then followed by an awkward wail. An investigation revealed that the source of the ruckus was not a table fan that had been on too long, but Veer's rendition of a violin segment from a classical piece of music. Suffice to say, his performance ended abruptly as a million paper balls headed his way. Veer's dodging skills

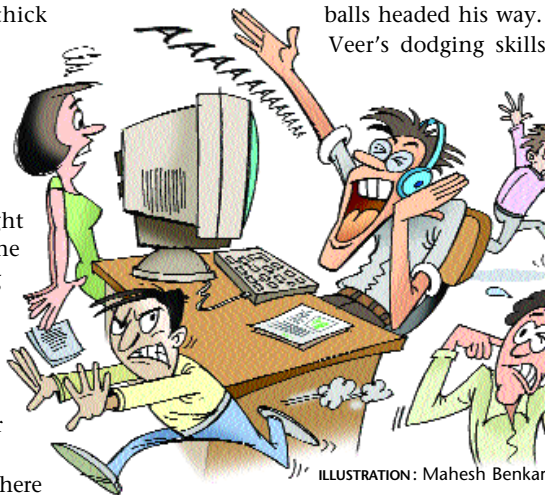


ILLUSTRATION: Mahesh Benkar

have thus improved, though it is his singing that needs help.

Even as we successfully quelled Veer, a shout of "we need it now", was heard from the Test Centre. Deadlines not only put people on the edge, but have also been known to demand sacrifices—the latest victim was Yatish. He is a Test Centre reviewer and perhaps the biggest fan of Tux, the Linux penguin. His hard disk was immediately required for the purpose of running a test—the very same hard disk that housed his beloved Linux. He

was not pleased and as misty tears clouded his vision we caught a whisper of "I'll never forget you, my dear," as he hit the format button.

Troubles at the Test Centre were not restricted to Yatish though. Hatim, our deputy head of the Test Centre, was the latest to take part in the not-so-fun game of find-the-missing-editor. "So I just have to verify these numbers? No problem," said Hatim. Our editor however was frantically trying to close the August issue and was busy with other tasks. Hatim went back and forth between his desk and the editor's and before long, the night sky found him still awaiting a clearance. Frustrated beyond belief, he decided to boot up *Quake III Arena* for a quick frag session and promptly fell asleep holding the keyboard and the mouse. Things ended well as he got the required all-okay from the big-chief at an unearthly hour. The only problem was that it was so late that he had to crash at a friend's place and boy was he grouchy the next day!

Unearthly hours are regular guests here at Digit. Working non-stop through the weekends though, brings in the inevitable demand for nourishment. But that doesn't mean that we have to leave our chairs, heaven forbid! We have devised other solutions. Certain team members are diplomatically manipulated to stay back in case we need them for "some last minute references and cross checks". Incidentally, they happen to have vehicles at their service and are gullible to whines. Our taste buds are consulted, the weather is taken into consideration and a general discussion on what each person feels like eating ensues. So it's pizzas for lunch, then frankies at tea, *biryani* for dinner interspersed with hot *vada pavs* to drive away the chill and ice cream to beat the heat. And once the foodathon is over, we start thinking about what next to eat, until the grim reaper of deadlines (our editor) taps us demandingly on the head and we ignore our grumbling stomach till the next issue closing.

The circle completes itself. ■

## The Light Side Conquers All

This month saw a special treat for Club Digit members. Subscribers were invited to a special screening of *Star Wars Episode II: Attack of the Clones*. The event was held in six cities and gave us the unique opportunity to interact with our beloved readers. In Mumbai the venue was the Russian Cultural Centre and we had a blast! *Star Wars* fans from all walks of life thronged together and, as one of our writers put it, "had a jolly

good time". Although almost everyone missed identifying Ayesha Dharkar, the new Queen of Naboo, the highlight of the movie was the cool battle sequence involving everybody's favourite Jedi Master—Yoda. As he leapt into action, light-saber in hand, the entire venue erupted in excitement. There was much whistling and clapping and we were amazed as our seemingly gentle technology readers revealed their lighter side.